

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

MONDAY, 28 SEPTEMBER 2026

21 must-know stories, 21 Prelims facts, 17 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 852 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Collegium proposes second woman as apex court judge in 2026

The Supreme Court Collegium recommended the elevation of three High Court Chief Justices as judges of the Supreme Court. The recommendations were made during the Collegium meeting held on September 28, 2026. The recommended judges are Gujarat High Court Chief Justice Sunita Agarwal, Delhi High Court Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya, and Telangana High Court Chief Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh. Justice Sunita Agarwal's proposed elevation marks the second time in 2026 that a woman has been proposed to serve on the Supreme Court Bench. Justice Agarwal was initially appointed as an Allahabad High Court judge in November 2011 and became Gujarat High Court Chief Justice in July 2023. Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya previously served as Chief Justice of the Bombay High Court before moving to the Delhi High Court. Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh previously served as Chief Justice of the Tripura High Court before transferring to the Telangana High Court. The Collegium statement detailing these recommendations was published on the official website of the apex court.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Supreme Court Collegium, Justice Sunita Agarwal, Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya, Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh · **Prelims:** Justice Sunita Agarwal was appointed as a judge of the Allahabad High Court on November 21, 2011.; Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya took the oath of office as Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court on January 21, 2025.; Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh served as Acting Chief Justice of the Jharkhand High Court from December 20, 2022, to February 19, 2023.

Why it matters — Highlights the ongoing judicial appointments process via the Collegium system.; Marks a notable representation of women judges in the highest court of the country.

Static — The Supreme Court Collegium is the system for appointment and transfer of judges in the higher judiciary, evolving through three Supreme Court Judges Cases (1981, 1993, 1998). The Collegium is headed by the Chief Justice of India and comprises the four senior-most judges of the Supreme Court. Articles 124(2) and 217 of the Constitution govern the appointment of judges to the Supreme Court and High Courts respectively, with the executive having final appointment powers based on Collegium recommendations.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment, Appointment

[The Hindu: read the source](#) · [free copy on thehansindia.com](#) · also reported by Bar & Bench, The Indian Express

GS2

MAKE NOTES

FCRA Bill 2026: JPC To Hear MHA, Law Ministry, SBI Chief And Experts On Foreign Funding Rules

The Joint Parliamentary Committee examining the Foreign Contribution Regulation Amendment Bill 2026 held its second meeting at Parliament Annexe. Officials from the Ministry of Home Affairs and the Ministry of Law and Justice briefed committee members on the provisions of the proposed legislation. The panel heard views from domain experts and stakeholders including SBI Chairman Challa Sreenivasulu Setty and Delhi HC ASG Chetan Sharma. The newly constituted committee held its maiden meeting on September 18 where Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan explained the rationale and policy framework. The Bill was referred to the Joint Committee during the Monsoon Session after being introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25. Opposition parties including Congress, SP, and TMC opposed the amendments alleging they could be used to target NGOs and minority institutions. The government maintains the amendments aim to strengthen oversight, ensure transparency, prevent misuse, and safeguard national interests. The JPC is mandated to submit its report before the first week of the Winter Session 2026. The 2026 Bill proposes stricter reporting protocols, digitised compliance workflows, and tighter oversight to prevent the diversion of foreign funds.

When: September 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Joint Parliamentary Committee, Sanjay Jaiswal, Challa Sreenivasulu Setty, Chetan Sharma, Govind Mohan, Nityanand Rai · **Prelims:** The Foreign Contribution Regulation Amendment Bill 2026 was introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25.; The revised FCRA Rules 2026 were notified on June 22.; The Joint Parliamentary Committee is chaired by BJP MP Sanjay

Jaiswal.

Why it matters — Crucial for understanding how foreign contributions to NGOs, universities, and think tanks are monitored and regulated in India.; Highlights the legislative scrutiny process involving Joint Parliamentary Committees and stakeholder consultations on national security legislations.

Static — The Foreign Contribution Regulation Act regulates the acceptance and utilisation of foreign funds by individuals, associations, and companies to protect internal security. Joint Parliamentary Committees are ad hoc bodies constituted for a specific purpose, such as examining a particular Bill, consisting of MPs from both houses. The quorum for the sittings of the Joint Parliamentary Committee examining the FCRA Bill is fixed at one-third of its total membership.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

[republicworld.com: read the source](#) · also reported by *Economic Times*

GS2

MAKE NOTES

J&K Assembly passes statehood resolution with references to autonomy, Article 370; BJP walks out

The Jammu and Kashmir Assembly passed a resolution seeking the restoration of statehood on Monday. The resolution was originally moved by Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on September 25. Members of the National Conference and opposition parties moved amendments to include references to autonomy and Article 370. The resolution was passed by a majority vote following a prolonged debate in the House. BJP leaders strongly opposed the resolution and raised slogans while standing in the well of the House. Congress leader Nizamuddin accused the BJP of jingoism and subverting the Constitution during the debate. The BJP eventually staged a walkout from the Assembly before the resolution was finally passed.

When: September 2026 · **Where:** Jammu and Kashmir · **Who:** Omar Abdullah, Nizamuddin, BJP leaders · **Prelims:** The resolution was originally moved by Chief Minister Omar Abdullah.; The resolution was moved on September 25 and passed on Monday.; BJP leaders staged a walkout from the Assembly during the proceedings.

Why it matters — Highlights the ongoing political friction between regional parties in J&K and the central government over autonomy.; Serves as a crucial development for understanding Centre-state relations and federal dynamics in India.

Static — Article 370 of the Indian Constitution provided temporary special autonomous status to Jammu and Kashmir. On August 5, 2019, the President of India issued an order revoking the special status granted under Article 370. The Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019 split the state into two Union Territories: Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution

[Hindustan Times: read the source](#)

Governance & Policy

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court asks how children can have social media accounts, as underlying contracts are legally void

The Supreme Court raised this legal question regarding children's social media accounts and void contracts. The Supreme Court noted that minors are legally incompetent to enter contracts under Indian law, raising questions on how children can hold social media accounts and demanding a strict age threshold. Minors are legally incompetent to enter contracts under Indian law, notes SC; says social media firms must frame their platforms in conformity with Indian law, and enforce an age threshold of 18 years for 'membership'

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court of India · **Prelims:** Minors are legally incompetent to enter contracts under Indian law.; The Supreme Court suggested an age threshold of 18 years for social media membership.

Why it matters — Highlights the legal loophole in children accessing digital platforms through standard terms of service agreements.; Pushes for stricter regulatory compliance and enforcement of an 18-year age threshold by social media companies in India.

Static — Under the Indian Contract Act, 1872, a minor is legally incompetent to enter into a contract, and any agreement made with a minor is void ab initio. The Supreme Court of India is the highest judicial forum and final court of appeal under the Constitution of India. Data protection and child safety on digital platforms are governed by statutes like the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Polity & Constitution, Social Justice & Welfare, Society · Prelims angle: Judgment

[The Hindu: read the source](#)

International Relations

GS2

MAKE NOTES

14th India-UAE High Level Joint Task Force Meeting Held in Mumbai

India and the UAE held the 14th meeting of the High-Level Joint Task Force on Investments in Mumbai. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal co-chaired the meeting alongside Sheikh Hamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Managing Director of ADIA. India is exploring the sourcing of more liquefied natural gas and liquefied petroleum gas from the UAE to bolster energy security. Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserves Ltd and ADNOC signed an agreement for the UAE to store up to 30 million barrels of crude oil in India. The storage facilities involved include sites located at Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh and Chandikhol in Odisha. Both nations are also examining the possibility of storing a portion of India's strategic crude reserves in Fujairah, UAE. Bilateral trade between India and the UAE reached US\$101.25 billion in the financial year 2025-26. Both countries are working towards a shared ambition of achieving US\$200 billion in bilateral trade by 2032.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** Mumbai, Visakhapatnam, Chandikhol, Fujairah · **Who:** Piyush Goyal, Sheikh Hamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, ISPR, ADNOC · **Prelims:** The 14th India-UAE High Level Joint Task Force Meeting was held in Mumbai.; Bilateral trade between India and the UAE reached US\$101.25 billion in FY 2025-26.; Non-oil trade reached US\$76.2 billion in the year 2025.

Why it matters — Enhances India's energy security by diversifying LNG and LPG import sources amidst global market uncertainties.; Deepens bilateral economic integration, aiming for US\$200 billion in bilateral trade by 2032.

Static — The India-UAE High-Level Joint Task Force on Investments was established in 2013 to promote trade, investment and economic ties between the two countries. Strategic petroleum reserves are emergency fuel storage inventories maintained by countries to safeguard against sudden disruptions in global energy supplies. Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserves Limited is a special purpose vehicle under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas responsible for maintaining strategic crude oil reserves in India.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations

[PIB: read the source](#) · [free copy on thehansindia.com](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

India reiterates Indus Waters Treaty to remain in abeyance until Pakistan ends support for terrorism

India stated at the United Nations that the Indus Waters Treaty will remain in abeyance until Pakistan halts cross-border terrorism. The statement came in response to Pakistan raising bilateral river issues during a UN World Water Day 2026 event. India argued that treaties require goodwill, and Pakistan's state support for terrorism violates the foundational spirit of the water-sharing pact. India previously suspended the treaty following the Pahalgam terror attack linked to The Resistance Front, an outfit tied to Lashkar-e-Taiba. The envoy noted that Pakistan persistently rejected Indian requests to renegotiate treaty provisions despite significant technological, demographic, and climate changes over 65 years. India highlighted its domestic water governance initiatives, including the Jal Jeevan Mission's focus on women-led rural piped water management. The decision signals a strict diplomatic posture linking international transboundary water cooperation directly to regional security and counter-terrorism.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** United Nations, New York · **Who:** Harish Parvathaneni, India's Permanent Representative to the UN · **Prelims:** Under the IWT, Eastern rivers (Sutlej, Beas, Ravi) belong to India, while Western rivers (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab) are allocated primarily to Pakistan.; The Jal Jeevan Mission aims to provide functional piped water tap connections to rural households through community and women-led committees.

Why it matters — Reinforces India's firm stance that transboundary resource cooperation cannot function alongside state-sponsored cross-border terrorism.; Underscores the need to modernize 65-year-old river treaties to account for climate change, clean energy needs, and demographic growth.

Static — The Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) was signed in September 1960 between India and Pakistan, brokered by the World Bank. Under the treaty, the waters of three Eastern rivers (Ravi, Beas, Sutlej) are allocated exclusively to India. The three Western rivers (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab) are allocated to Pakistan, with India permitted specified domestic, non-consumptive, and run-of-the-river hydroelectric uses.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Internal Security · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[ddnews.gov.in: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Goyal-Greer meet likely to focus on India-US BTA, interim trade deal: Commerce Ministry

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal is scheduled to visit the United States from September 29 to October 5. The bilateral trade agreement and an interim trade deal are expected to remain a key focus during the visit. Goyal will participate in the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee, Wisconsin, and hold bilateral talks. He is likely to meet United States Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on the sidelines of the G20 meeting. Negotiations have covered market access, digital trade, supply-chain resilience, and non-tariff barriers. India aims to finalise the trade pact once Indian exporters receive a competitive advantage over rival exporting countries. The proposed interim agreement serves as a major milestone toward concluding a comprehensive bilateral trade agreement.

When: September 29 to October 5 · **Where:** United States · **Who:** Piyush Goyal and Jamieson Greer · **Prelims:** Piyush Goyal is the Union Commerce and Industry Minister.; Jamieson Greer is the United States Trade Representative (USTR).; The G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting is being held in Milwaukee, Wisconsin.

Why it matters — *Crucial for enhancing bilateral economic ties and market access for Indian exporters in the United States.; Represents a strategic step toward concluding a comprehensive India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement.*

Static — Bilateral trade agreements are formal treaties between two nations to regulate trade tariffs, quotas, and market access to promote economic cooperation. Interim trade deals serve as early harvest or stepping-stone arrangements before negotiating comprehensive free trade agreements between partner nations. The Office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR) is responsible for developing and recommending US trade policy to the President.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

[BusinessLine: read the source](#) · [free copy on msn.com](#) · also reported by *Economic Times, PIB, swarajyamag.com*

GS2

MAKE NOTES

IBSA FMs call for urgent, text-based UNSC reforms; endorse India's critical minerals initiative, condemn Pahalgam terror attack

India, Brazil and South Africa held the 14th IBSA Trilateral Ministerial Commission on the sidelines of the 81st Session of the UN General Assembly in New York. The Ministers expressed deep concern over the paralysis within the Inter-Governmental Negotiations and called for formal, text-based UNSC reforms within a fixed timeframe. The grouping endorsed India's Critical Minerals Circularity Initiative under the G20, focusing on technological innovations like recycling, urban mining, and second-life batteries. The joint statement unequivocally condemned the April 2025 terrorist attack in Pahalgam, Jammu and Kashmir, and called for zero tolerance against UN-listed terrorist entities. The Foreign Ministers urged the expeditious adoption of the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism at the UN. They expressed serious concern over unilateral tariffs and protectionist measures, pressing for comprehensive reforms of the WTO, IMF, and World Bank. The Ministers voiced grave concern over escalating Middle East tensions and supported a two-state solution to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict alongside unhindered humanitarian aid. They congratulated India on hosting the 18th BRICS Summit in September 2026 and holding the AI Impact Summit earlier in the year.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** New York · **Who:** S Jaishankar, Ronald Lamola, Mauro Vieira · **Prelims:** The 14th IBSA Trilateral Ministerial Commission was held on the sidelines of UNGA81 in New York.; The meeting was attended by Ronald Lamola (South Africa), S Jaishankar (India), and Mauro Vieira (Brazil).; The IBSA grouping endorsed India's Critical Minerals Circularity Initiative under the G20.

Why it matters — *Highlights the collective voice of the Global South on key geopolitical reforms like the expansion of the UN Security Council.; Demonstrates India's leadership in sustainable supply chains through the endorsement of its Critical Minerals Circularity Initiative.*

Static — The India-Brazil-South Africa (IBSA) Dialogue Forum is a tripartite grouping established in 2003 to promote South-South cooperation and consensus among three large, multi-ethnic democracies. The UN Security Council Inter-Governmental Negotiations (IGN) process handles reforms of the UNSC, but progress has stalled for decades due to lack of a single text-based negotiating document. The World Trade Organization (WTO) and Bretton Woods institutions (IMF and World Bank) were established post-WWII, and developing countries frequently demand governance reforms for better representation.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Infrastructure & Energy, Internal Security

[tribuneindia.com: read the source](#)

Health

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court questions FSSAI for delay in roll-out of warning labels on packaged foods

The Supreme Court reserved its judgment on the proposed front-of-pack labelling rules for packaged food and beverages. The bench directed all parties involved in the matter to submit their final written arguments within three days. The apex court sought greater clarity from the Centre and FSSAI on the Front-of-Pack Nutrition Labelling framework. FSSAI proposed a red hexagonal warning label, drawing from the Canadian approach, for products exceeding nutrient thresholds. Following judicial questioning, FSSAI abandoned its two-stage implementation plan in favor of a single-phase rollout. The regulator indicated it would require approximately four months to issue and finalise the draft regulations. The warning labels are intended to clearly identify products containing high levels of fat, salt, or sugar. The upcoming final framework will determine covered foods, exact nutrient thresholds, and the compliance timeline for manufacturers.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court, Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) · **Prelims:** FSSAI proposed a red hexagonal warning label for high sugar, salt, or fat foods.; The design draws broadly from the Canadian approach.; FSSAI indicated it expects to issue and finalise draft regulations in about four months.

Why it matters — *Crucial for regulating public health and addressing lifestyle diseases linked to excessive sugar, salt, and fat consumption.; Shapes the future regulatory framework for food manufacturers and labelling standards in India.*

Static — The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) is a statutory body established under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006. FSSAI operates under the administrative control of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare. The primary function of FSSAI is to lay down science-based standards for articles of food and regulate their manufacture, storage, distribution, sale, and import.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Health, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

[msn.com: read the source](#)

Economy

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Cabinet approves Rs 62,500 crore Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme to boost production, exports and Indian brands

The Union Cabinet has reportedly approved a Rs 62,500 crore scheme targeting mobile phone manufacturing. The policy initiative aims to boost domestic electronics production, enhance exports, and support Indian brands. The provided text contains insufficient detailed reporting on the specific guidelines, targets, and outlays of the scheme.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union Cabinet · **Prelims:** Approved financial outlay for the mobile manufacturing scheme is Rs 62,500 crore.

***Why it matters** — Supports India's ambition to become a global electronics manufacturing hub.; Aims to enhance competitiveness and market share of domestic Indian phone brands.*

Static — The Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for Large Scale Electronics Manufacturing was launched in 2020 by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology. PLI schemes offer financial incentives on incremental sales of goods manufactured in domestic units to attract major investments. Promoting domestic electronics manufacturing is aimed at reducing import dependence and integrating Indian firms into global value chains.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme, Data/Stats

[ddnews.gov.in: read the source](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Quick Estimates of Index of Industrial Production and Use- Based Index for the Month of August 2026 (Base 2022-23=100)

It was published as part of the regular monthly release cycle on the 28th of the month by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation released the Quick Estimates of the Index of Industrial Production for August 2026, showing an overall growth rate of 8.0 percent. The Quick Estimate of Index of Industrial Production (IIP) is released on 28 th of every month (or next working day if 28 th is a holiday). The index is compiled with data received from source agencies, which in turn receive the data from the producing factories/ establishments. These Quick Estimates will undergo revision in subsequent releases as per the revision policy of IIP. Key Highlights: The IIP growth rate for the month of August 2026 is 8.0 percent which was 6.7 percent (Quick Estimate) in the month of July 2026. The growth rates of the sectors, Mining & Quarrying, Manufacturing, Electricity & Gas Supply and Water Supply, Sewerage & Waste Management for the month of August 2026 a

When: August 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation · **Prelims:** IIP growth rate for August 2026 is 8.0 percent.; Base year for the current IIP series is 2022-23 equals 100.; Manufacturing sector growth rate for August 2026 is 9.0 percent.

***Why it matters** — Provides vital data on the physical volume of industrial output for macroeconomic monitoring and policymaking.; Tracks performance across core sectors like manufacturing, mining, and electricity to gauge broader economic health.*

Static — The Index of Industrial Production is a composite indicator that measures the short-term changes in the volume of production of industrial products during a given period. In India, the IIP is compiled and published monthly by the National Statistical Office under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. The base year for the current series of the Index of Industrial Production is 2022-23 equals 100.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Infrastructure & Energy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Report/Index, Data/Stats

[PIB: read the source](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court refuses to stay Centre's decision to levy MDR on merchant UPI transactions over Rs. 2,000

The Supreme Court refused to stay the Centre's decision to impose a Merchant Discount Rate on specified UPI person-to-merchant transactions. The petition challenged the imposition of MDR on UPI payments exceeding Rs. 2,000, which is scheduled to take effect from October 15. The legal challenge led the apex court to seek responses from the Centre and other respondents within four weeks. The Centre defended the move in court by stating that 96 percent of people using the payment gateway are exempt. The Supreme Court observed that the issue at hand is less legal and more technical in nature. The new UPI framework announced earlier this month introduces an MDR of 0.4 percent on UPI payments above Rs. 2,000. The government maintained that person-to-person transactions will continue to remain completely free irrespective of the amount transferred.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court, Centre · **Prelims:** The MDR rate set for specified UPI P2M transactions over Rs. 2,000 is 0.4 percent.; The implementation date for the new UPI framework involving MDR is October 15.; Approximately 96 percent of all person-to-merchant transactions remain exempt and unaffected by this decision.

Why it matters — It impacts the ongoing debate on digital payment costs, financial inclusion, and the commercial sustainability of payment service providers in India.; It clarifies the judicial approach towards economic and technical policy decisions implemented by the executive.

Static — Merchant Discount Rate is a fee paid by a merchant to a bank for accepting payments from customers through digital payment methods like credit cards, debit cards, or UPI. Unified Payments Interface is an instant real-time payment system developed by the National Payments Corporation of India facilitating inter-bank transactions. The Supreme Court of India is the highest judicial forum and final court of appeal under the Constitution, possessing power of judicial review.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

[Hindustan Times: read the source](#) · also reported by [Moneycontrol.com](#), [The Hindu](#), [The Times of India](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

RBI MPC October 2026: Sanjay Malhotra & co may raise interest rates to 5.50% as inflation broadens, poll finds

A majority of economists polled by Reuters expect the Reserve Bank of India to raise interest rates by 25 basis points to 5.50% in October. This anticipated move would mark the central bank's first rate increase since February 2023. The tightening cycle is triggered by rising inflation, which accelerated to 4.82% in August, exceeding the RBI's 4% medium-term target. Consumer price increases were driven largely by sharply higher energy and food costs, alongside global pressures from Middle East conflicts. The rupee has weakened by about 6% this year, adding pressure on the RBI to defend the currency with rate hikes. Minutes from the August policy meeting showed policymakers, including Governor Sanjay Malhotra, favoured rate hikes if inflation broadened. A slim majority of economists also expect another 25 basis point hike by December, bringing the expected peak rate to 5.75%. Poll medians suggest rates will remain at 5.75% until at least mid-2028, marking one of the shallowest hiking cycles in a decade.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** Bengaluru, India · **Who:** Sanjay Malhotra, Governor of the RBI · **Prelims:** Inflation accelerated to 4.82% in August, exceeding the RBI's 4% medium-term target for the third consecutive month.; Nearly 60% of economists in the Reuters poll expected the repo rate to rise by 25 basis points to 5.50%.; The upcoming monetary policy meeting is scheduled for October 5 to 7.

Why it matters — Signals a shift in monetary policy stance toward tightening as inflationary pressures broaden.; Highlights the spillover effects of global energy price shocks and US Federal Reserve rate hikes on domestic monetary policy.

Static — The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is India's central banking institution established on April 1, 1935, under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) is a statutory body constituted under Section 45ZB of the RBI Act to determine the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target. The MPC comprises six members: three officials of the RBI and three external members appointed by the central government, with the RBI Governor acting as the chairperson.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

[Economic Times: read the source](#) · [free copy on msn.com](#) · also reported by [BizzBuzz](#)

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

India-UAE target \$200bn bilateral trade by 2032; commit to local currencies, payments, digital initiatives

India and the UAE agreed on the timely implementation of initiatives for local currency trade settlement, payment integration, and central bank digital currencies. The agreement was reached during the 14th India-UAE High Level Joint Task Force on Investments meeting held in Mumbai. Both nations have set a target to increase bilateral trade to \$200 billion by 2032, building upon the \$101.25 billion reached in 2025-26. Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal stated that local currency settlement, using rupees and dirhams, is picking up and is now in double digits. The two sides are exploring expanding strategic petroleum reserves in India and potential subsea pipelines for gas supply resilience. A working group will be established across six maritime areas, including ship ownership, port development, and ship manufacturing. Discussions also included civil aviation cooperation, an aviation and logistics hub in Dholera, and a Food Park project in Gujarat. The UAE has already invested \$25 billion in India and intends to invest another \$25 billion toward a future \$100 billion goal.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** Mumbai, India · **Who:** Piyush Goyal and Sheikh Hamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan · **Prelims:** The 14th India-UAE High Level Joint Task Force meeting took place in Mumbai.; Bilateral trade between India and the UAE reached \$101.25 billion in 2025-26.; The India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) was implemented in May 2022.

Why it matters — Strengthens bilateral economic resilience by reducing dependence on third-party currencies through local currency trade settlements.; Expands strategic cooperation into critical sectors like energy security, maritime infrastructure, space, and artificial intelligence.

Static — The India-UAE High Level Joint Task Force on Investments was established in 2013 to promote trade, investment, and economic ties between the two countries. India and the UAE implemented a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in May 2022 to boost bilateral economic exchange. A bilateral investment treaty (BIT) was implemented in August 2024 to protect and promote investments between the two nations.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Economy, International Relations

[Mint: read the source](#) · [free copy on msn.com](#) · also reported by [BusinessLine](#), [All India Radio \(NewsOnAir\)](#), [Economic Times](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

India's bid to keep carbon cash home as Europe adds a new trade cost

The European Union introduced the definitive phase of its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism in January 2026, imposing border carbon costs on imports. The policy requires European importers to purchase certificates based on emissions embedded in imported goods, allowing deductions for carbon prices paid domestically. Indian exporters face declining competitiveness and reduced margins, with the United Kingdom also preparing to launch a similar border carbon mechanism in January 2027. The European Union takes nearly two-fifths of Indian steel exports, while an ICRIER study projects a potential twenty-four percent drop in steel shipments. India relies on coal-heavy production routes for primary steel, making its metals significantly more emissions-intensive than the global average. To retain carbon revenue domestically, India notified the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme under the Energy Conservation Amendment Act, administered by the Bureau of Energy Efficiency. Under the scheme, over 700 industrial entities receive emission-intensity targets across two-year compliance cycles beginning in financial year 2025-26. Britain agreed to recognise India's carbon credit scheme, though a large gap persists between domestic carbon prices and European emission allowances.

When: January 2026 · **Where:** India and the European Union · **Who:** European Union, Bureau of Energy Efficiency, NITI Aayog, and ICRIER · **Prelims:** The EU CBAM covers six initial sectors: iron and steel, aluminium, cement, fertilisers, electricity, and hydrogen.; India's Carbon Credit Trading Scheme was notified in June 2023 under the Energy Conservation (Amendment) Act.; One Carbon Credit Certificate under India's scheme equals one tonne of carbon dioxide equivalent reduction.

Why it matters — *Helps shield Indian steel and aluminium exporters from margin erosion caused by foreign carbon levies.; Channels industrial compliance revenue into domestic clean-energy transitions and power grid modernisation.*

Static — The Energy Conservation (Amendment) Act, 2022 empowered the Central Government to establish a domestic carbon credit trading market and specify non-fossil energy consumption mandates. The Bureau of Energy Efficiency is a statutory body set up under the Energy Conservation Act, 2001, functioning under the Ministry of Power to improve energy efficiency. The Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism is designed by the European Union to prevent carbon leakage by equalising carbon prices between domestic production and imports.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Environment & Ecology, International Relations

[Economic Times: read the source](#) · [free copy on msn.com](#)

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Centre Can Invoke S.100 Patents Act To Make Exorbitantly Priced Patented Drugs And Sell On Non-Commercial ...

The Kerala High Court ruled that the Centre can invoke Section 100 of the Patents Act to manufacture and distribute patented medicines on a non-commercial basis to needy patients when prices are exorbitant. The judgment arose from a 2022 petition filed by a breast cancer patient seeking affordable access to the expensive drug Ribociclib, who passed away during the proceedings. Following the petitioner's death, the High Court took suo motu cognisance of the larger issue concerning the high prices of patented life-saving medicines. The Centre and pharmaceutical industry representatives argued that Section 100 could only be invoked strictly for government purposes and not for individual patients, a view the court rejected. Justice Harisankar V Menon stated that 'for the purposes of government' includes supplying products manufactured using a patent to a needy patient on a non-commercial basis. The court noted that the government must first collect relevant information and assess whether a medicine's price is actually unaffordable before taking action under Section 100. The court emphasized the state's obligation to ensure access to healthcare and life-saving treatments while balancing affordable medical access with adequate innovation incentives.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** Kerala · **Who:** Justice Harisankar V Menon · **Prelims:** Section 100 of the Patents Act deals with the government's power to use inventions for government purposes.; Ribociclib is a CDK 4/6 inhibitor drug used for treating HR+/HER2- metastatic breast cancer.; The 21-day course of Ribociclib mentioned in the petition cost around Rs 58,140.

Why it matters — *Provides a strong legal pathway for the government to intervene and ensure affordable access to expensive life-saving drugs.; Reinterprets 'government purposes' under Section 100 to directly encompass the welfare of needy patients.*

Static — The Patents Act, 1970 is the primary legislation governing patent law in India, amended significantly to comply with TRIPS agreements when India joined the WTO. Section 100 of the Patents Act, 1970 empowers the Central Government and persons authorised by it to use inventions for government purposes without the patentee's authorization. Compulsory licensing (under Section 92 and 84) is another vital mechanism in Indian patent law, allowing governments to authorize the production of a patented drug without the patent owner's consent during public health emergencies.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Economy, Polity & Constitution, Science & Technology · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

[timesofindia.indiatimes.com: read the source](#) · also reported by *Times of India, The Hindu*

Infrastructure & Energy

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Cabinet approves Rs. 8,300 crore coastal highway project between Rameshwar and Paradeep in Odisha

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs approved the Rameshwar to Paradeep coastal highway project in Odisha costing Rs. 8,300.79 crore. The project was initiated due to rising traffic demand, heavy local commuter traffic, and congestion on the existing NH-316 corridor. The core issue addressed is improving long-distance travel efficiency and logistics connectivity along Odisha's coastal region. The highway will span 160.18 kilometres across Khurda, Puri, Kendrapada, and Jagatsinghpur districts under the Hybrid Annuity Model. Package one includes a 79.4-kilometre four-lane access-controlled highway between Rameshwar and Konark. Package two involves an 80.78-kilometre two-lane highway with paved shoulders between Konark and Paradeep. The project aligns with the PM GatiShakti National Master Plan, linking nine economic nodes and five logistics nodes. Upon completion, travel time will reduce by nearly two and a half hours alongside lower fuel consumption and carbon emissions. The project will generate around 53.61 lakh direct and 67.01 lakh indirect man-days of employment during construction and implementation.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** Odisha · **Who:** Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs · **Prelims:** Total project cost is Rs. 8,300.79 crore.; Total length of the highway is 160.18 kilometres.; The project covers Khurda, Puri, Kendrapada, and Jagatsinghpur districts.

Why it matters — It enhances multimodal connectivity by linking key ports, airports, railway stations, and logistics parks in Odisha.; It supports regional economic growth by connecting multiple special economic zones, food parks, and industrial clusters.

Static — The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) evaluates and clears major economic policy and infrastructure proposals for the central government. The Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) combines EPC (Engineering, Procurement, and Construction) and BOT (Build, Operate, Transfer) models for infrastructure development. Under HAM, the government pays a percentage of the project cost during construction, while the remaining is paid as annuities during operation.

Syllabus: GS3: Infrastructure & Energy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

ddnews.gov.in: read the source

Environment & Ecology

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Assam Government Encroaches Into a World Heritage Site in India's Northeast

Recent reports highlighted that the Assam government encroached into a UNESCO World Heritage Site in Northeast India. The Assam government has encroached into core tiger and Bengal florican habitats inside Manas National Park. The encroached area is part of Manas National Park's core tiger and Bengal florican habitats.

When: 2026-09-28 · **Where:** Assam, India · **Who:** Assam Government · **Prelims:** The encroached area is part of Manas National Park.; The affected zones include core tiger and Bengal florican habitats.; The park is located in Assam, Northeast India.

Why it matters — Highlights systemic challenges in balancing state infrastructure or administrative actions with wildlife conservation.; Brings attention to the vulnerability of core habitats in UNESCO World Heritage Sites.

Static — Manas National Park is a UNESCO World Heritage Site located in the state of Assam, India. It is designated as a Project Tiger reserve, an elephant reserve, and a biosphere reserve. The park is contiguous with the Royal Manas National Park in Bhutan.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, History, Art & Culture · Prelims angle: Species, Place in news

[The Diplomat: read the source](https://the-diplomat: read the source)

GS1 GS3

MAKE NOTES

El Nino may turn 'very strong' by late 2026: IRI; experts see elevated risk for India

The International Research Institute for Climate and Society stated that the El Nino weather pattern is strengthening and may become very strong by late 2026 and early 2027. The Nino 3.4 index reached plus 3.0 degrees Celsius in mid-September, triggering heightened concerns over elevated climate risks for India. All 22 surveyed models forecast very strong El Nino conditions through the 2026-2027 winter season. The IRI estimated a 100 percent probability of El Nino through February 2027, which will decline to 61 percent by mid-2027. The Indian Ocean Dipole is expected to become strongly positive from September through December 2026 before returning to neutral conditions in early 2027. El Nino is typically associated with weaker monsoon rainfall and can affect crop output in India. A positive Indian Ocean Dipole often occurs alongside El Nino and can sometimes offset its negative effects on rainfall. Experts note that El Nino impacts depend on multiple factors, including regional sea-surface temperatures and winter weather patterns, beyond the Nino 3.4 index alone.

When: September 2026 · **Where:** Pacific Ocean, India · **Who:** International Research Institute for Climate and Society · **Prelims:** The Nino 3.4 index reached plus 3.0 degrees Celsius in mid-September.; The IRI surveyed 22 models, comprising 13 dynamical and nine statistical models.; The probability of El Nino was placed at 100 percent through February 2027.

Why it matters — It raises early warnings for Indian agriculture, water availability, and rural economy due to potential monsoon disruptions.; It highlights the complex interaction between Pacific Ocean temperatures and the Indian Ocean Dipole in shaping South Asian weather.

Static — El Nino is a climate pattern characterized by the unusual warming of surface waters in the eastern and central Pacific Ocean. The El Nino Southern Oscillation cycle affects global weather, often causing droughts in some regions and heavy rainfall in others. The Indian Ocean Dipole is defined by the difference in sea-surface temperatures between the western and eastern tropical Indian Ocean.

Syllabus: GS1 / GS3: Environment & Ecology, Geography

[Economic Times: read the source](#) · [free copy on tribuneindia.com](#) · also reported by Mongabay India

Science & Technology

GS3

MAKE NOTES

ISRO to launch NVS-03 to restore NavIC service late 2026

ISRO is targeting the launch of the NVS-03 navigation satellite between October 15 and 20 to restore the NavIC service. The NavIC standalone positioning service is currently inactive because India has only three operational navigation satellites in space, falling short of the mandatory four-satellite requirement. Without four operational satellites, the armed forces cannot use NavIC for missile navigation, warship coordination, and troop movement support. ISRO has not launched a successful navigation satellite since May 29, 2023, when NVS-01 was sent to space. The subsequent NVS-02 satellite launched on January 29, 2025, failed to reach its intended orbit due to a pyro valve signal loss in the engine. A successful launch of NVS-03 will complete the four-satellite quorum, restoring absolute navigational control and tactical independence for India. Union space minister Jitendra Singh informed Lok Sabha in July that two further satellites, NVS-04 and NVS-05, are in advanced stages of realisation. NavIC provides a standard positioning service for civilians and an encrypted restricted service exclusively for authorised military users.

When: Late 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** ISRO, Jitendra Singh · **Prelims:** NVS-01 was successfully launched on May 29, 2023.; NVS-02 was launched on January 29, 2025, but failed to reach its intended orbit due to a pyro valve signal loss.; Union space minister Jitendra Singh informed Lok Sabha in July that NVS-04 and NVS-05 are in an advanced stage of realisation.

Why it matters — Restores strategic autonomy and tactical advantage for Indian security forces without foreign dependencies.; Ensures secure, uncompromised communication, mobility, and targeting data during geopolitical crises or conflicts.

Static — NavIC, formerly known as IRNSS, is an independent regional satellite navigation system developed by ISRO to provide accurate position information service in India and region extending up to 1,500 km around it. The system consists of a constellation of satellites with a Geostationary Earth Orbit and Inclined Geosynchronous Orbit configuration, designed to provide continuous coverage over the Indian landmass. A minimum of four satellites are required in a navigation constellation to determine a precise three-dimensional position and correct time errors from device internal clocks.

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology

[timesofindia.indiatimes.com: read the source](#)

Defence

GS3

MAKE NOTES

LCA Mk2, AMCA first flight dates confirmed: Defence Secretary reveals timeline for India's next-gen fighter jets

The official disclosure of clear development and flight timelines by the Defence Secretary put these next-generation fighter programs in the news. Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh confirmed the official first flight timelines for India's indigenous LCA Mk2 and AMCA fighter jet programs. India's LCA Mk2 medium weight fighter prototype is expected to fly by September 2027. The country's Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft, or AMCA, is targeted for its first flight in September 2028. Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh provided clear timelines for these military aircraft programs. Test flights are set to occur between June and September next year. These developments are crucial for enhancing India's air combat capabilities against regional threats.

When: September 2027 (LCA Mk2 flight), September 2028 (AMCA flight) · **Where:** India · **Who:** Rajesh Kumar Singh (Defence Secretary) · **Prelims:** LCA Mk2 first flight is expected by September 2027.; AMCA first flight is targeted for September 2028.; Defence Secretary who revealed the timelines: Rajesh Kumar Singh.

Why it matters — Marks a critical step toward achieving self-reliance (Atmanirbhar Bharat) in advanced military aerospace technology.; Provides a concrete timeline for bolstering the operational capabilities of the Indian Air Force.

Static — The Tejas Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) program was initiated by the Indian government in the 1980s to replace aging MiG-21 fighters. The Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA) under the DRDO manages the design and development of India's indigenous fighter aircraft. Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) serves as the primary manufacturing partner for the production of LCA prototypes and operational jets.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence

[Economic Times: read the source](#)

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

INDIAN ARMED FORCES CONTINGENT DEPARTS FOR JOINT MILITARY EXERCISE KAZIND-2026

A 60-member Indian Armed Forces contingent departed for Oskemen, Kazakhstan, to participate in the ninth edition of Exercise KAZIND-2026. The exercise is scheduled to be conducted from 28 September to 11 October 2026. The primary aim is to enhance interoperability and strengthen joint counter-terrorism capabilities in a sub-conventional environment under a UN mandate.

[PIB: source](#)

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY

QUICK READ

Indian Railways Approves Rs. 223 Crore for Kavach 4.0 on 614.75 Route Kilometres of Varanasi Division

Indian Railways approved two hundred twenty three crore rupees for installing Kavach 4.0 on the Varanasi Division. The project covers 614.75 route kilometres of the Varanasi Division under the North Eastern Railway. The initiative aims to extend Kavach 4.0 coverage across identified balance sections to strengthen safety infrastructure. Kavach is an indigenously developed Automatic Train Protection system designed to enhance overall operational safety.

[PIB: source](#)

GOVERNANCE & POLICY

SCHEME

QUICK READ

Centre set to seek Cabinet nod to extend a dozen flagship welfare schemes

The interim extensions of these schemes are set to expire on 30 September, ahead of assembly elections in several states in 2027. The central government is preparing to seek Cabinet approval for extending around a dozen flagship welfare schemes whose interim extensions are ending soon.

[Mint: source](#)

INTERNAL SECURITY

QUICK READ

Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Shri Amit Shah inaugurates the Conference on 'PRAHAAR - CT Policy and Strategy' in New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurated the Conference on PRAHAAR - CT Policy and Strategy in New Delhi. The conference deliberated on the seven pillars of PRAHAAR through a whole-of-society approach against terrorism. The seven pillars include Prevention, Response, Aggregating Internal Capacities, Human Rights, Attenuating Conditions for Terrorism, Aligning International Efforts, and Recovery & Resilience.

[PIB: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

SCO national coordinators' meeting begins in Pakistan; India among participants

India will attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) national coordinators' meeting hosted by Pakistan from September 28 to 30. The meeting is scheduled to finalize and approve the official calendar of events under Pakistan's presidency. The core issue is balancing participation in Eurasian multilateral diplomacy against a decade-long absence of substantive bilateral relations with Pakistan.

[Times of India: source](#)

HISTORY, ART & CULTURE

QUICK READ

Jharkhand's Traditional Musical Instrument Mandar Gets GI Tag

Jharkhand's traditional folk musical instrument 'Mandar' has been granted Geographical Indication status by the Geographical Indications Registry in Chennai. The GI application was filed in 2021 to protect the instrument's distinctive construction, traditional manufacturing techniques, and acoustic qualities. Securing this status ensures legal protection for the traditional craft and prevents unauthorized commercial use of the regional heritage item.

[newindianexpress.com: source](#)

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

SCHEME

QUICK READ

India-France Space Cooperation Enters New Phase with Focus on Human Spaceflight, Start-ups and New Space Ecosystem: Dr. Jitendra Singh

A high-level French delegation visited New Delhi to meet Indian science ministers and officials to discuss ongoing and future bilateral space and scientific collaborations. Union Minister Dr. Jitendra Singh and a French delegation led by Prof. Philippe Baptiste met in New Delhi to discuss expanding India-France space and technological cooperation.

[PIB: source](#)

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

Air Forces Unite for Exercise Tarang Shakti 2026 in India

The Indian Air Force commenced the operational phase of the multilateral air exercise Tarang Shakti 2026 at Jodhpur. The exercise is themed "Power in Partnership" and runs from September 26 to October 12, bringing together air forces from eight countries. Seven Friendly Foreign Countries participating alongside the IAF are Australia, the United States, the UAE, France, Germany, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh.

[thestatesman.com: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

PLACE IN NEWS

QUICK READ

UN adopts First Declaration on Sea Level Rise

Global mean sea level is currently rising by about 4 to 5 mm a year, threatening low-lying atolls and island states. The UN General Assembly declaration provides a political commitment regarding statehood and maritime zones, but it is not a binding treaty. Retained statehood addresses legal continuity but does not stop physical flooding, land loss, and salt intrusion that make atolls uninhabitable.

[Insights on India: source](#)

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE

SCHEME

QUICK READ

Pradhan Mantri Anusuchit Jaati Abhyuday Yojna (PM-AJAY)

More than Rs 1,730 crore has been released directly to states under the Grants-in-Aid component of PM-AJAY from FY 2021-22 to FY 2025-26. The funding extended skilling and livelihood support to over 2.5 lakh individual and group beneficiaries across the country. PM-AJAY is a merger scheme combining three erstwhile centrally sponsored schemes: PMAGY, SCA to SCSP, and BJRCY.

[PIB: source](#)

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED

QUICK READ

Honble Union Minister for Fisheries Animal Husbandry and Dairying & Panchayatiraj Shri Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh launched Live Stock insurance portal

The Department of Animal Husbandry & Dairying (DAHD), Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying, Government of India, today launched the Livestock Insurance Portal (<https://rashtriyapashubima.dahd.gov.in>), a comprehensive digital platform aimed at transforming livestock insurance delivery across the country under the Livestock Insurance activity of National Livestock Mission (NLM).

[PIB: source](#)

INTERNAL SECURITY

QUICK READ

HM Amit Shah calls for stronger mechanism to combat terrorism; Launches new extradition portal

Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurated the Conference on PRAHAAR – National CT Policy and Strategy in New Delhi. The government has adopted a zero-tolerance policy against all forms and manifestations of terrorism under Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The PRAHAAR strategy deliberated upon seven pillars including prevention, response, internal capacities, human rights, and international efforts.

[newsonair.gov.in: source](https://newsonair.gov.in)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

Second India-Fiji Bilateral Joint Working Group Meeting Held in New Delhi

The second India-Fiji Bilateral Joint Working Group meeting was held in New Delhi on September 28, 2026. Discussions focused on strengthening bilateral defence and maritime cooperation, including greater collaboration in the defence industry. Both sides reaffirmed their shared commitment to a free, open, inclusive, and secure Indo-Pacific region.

[PIB: source](#)

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

SCHEME

QUICK READ

TakeMe2Space Plans India's First Orbital Data Centre Mission

Hyderabad-based spacetechnology startup TakeMe2Space will launch India's first networked orbital data centre mission on SpaceX's Falcon 9 in 2028. The 2028 mission will feature two 100 kg MOI constellation satellites equipped with 10 Nvidia Thor GPUs each, 100 TB of storage, and a multispectral imager. Optical inter-satellite links will enable the pair of spacecraft to share workloads and operate as a distributed computer in orbit.

[timesofindia.indiatimes.com: source](https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

PLACE IN NEWS

QUICK READ

Indian Peafowl Recorded for the First Time at Orang National Park

The Indian peafowl (*Pavo cristatus*) has been officially recorded for the first time at Orang National Park and Tiger Reserve in Assam. The landmark observation and photographic confirmation were made by wildlife photographer Nejib Ahmed and cinematographer Chandan Saikia. Forest staff had earlier reported sightings of an unidentified bird resembling the Indian peafowl near the Rowmari and Hazaribagh anti-poaching camps.

[msn.com: source](https://msn.com)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

BRICS Nations adopt New Delhi Declaration 2026

The 18th BRICS Summit adopted the New Delhi Declaration, placing climate-linked trade measures at the center of Global South economic diplomacy. The declaration explicitly opposes unilateral, punitive, discriminatory, and protectionist measures such as carbon border adjustment mechanisms. This opposition targets the European Union's operational CBAM regime and the United Kingdom's planned CBAM starting January 1, 2027.

[hindustantimes.com: source](https://hindustantimes.com)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

QUICK READ

NGT records expansion of Soor Sarovar Bird Sanctuary in Agra to 798.1505 hectares

The National Green Tribunal recorded the expansion of the Soor Sarovar Bird Sanctuary in Agra to a total area of 798.1505 hectares. This expansion followed a series of notifications issued in compliance with the recommendations of the Central Empowered Committee. The core issue involved the time-bound implementation of CEC recommendations pursuant to a September 23, 2022 order of the Supreme Court.

[aninews.in: source](#)

ECONOMY

REPORT/INDEX

QUICK READ

The implications of NITI Aayog's net zero finance report for India: a tempered ambition

The London School of Economics and Political Science published an analysis on NITI Aayog's net zero finance report. NITI Aayog released a report examining net zero finance implications for India, highlighting financial pathways and challenges.

[The London School of Economics and Political Science: source](#)

GOVERNANCE & POLICY

SCHEME

QUICK READ

UP Government to Take Strict Action Against Hospitals Violating Ayushman Scheme Norms

The Uttar Pradesh government has decided to take strict action against hospitals failing to comply with the rules and standards of the Ayushman scheme. The action follows instructions from Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath to ensure proper implementation of the healthcare initiative. A four-member team has been constituted by the State Health Agency to conduct surprise inspections of empanelled hospitals.

[newsonair.gov.in: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

Article by EAM in The Gleaner -The deep-rooted and ever evolving India-Jamaica partnership

The publication of the article by the External Affairs Minister detailing bilateral ties in The Gleaner. External Affairs Minister published an article in The Gleaner highlighting the deep-rooted and ever-evolving India-Jamaica partnership.

[Ministry of External Affairs: source](#)

ECONOMY

JUDGMENT

AGREEMENT/MOU

QUICK READ

Supreme Court Disposes of Appeals by Authority for Advance Rulings Against High Court Judgment Quashing AAR's Rejection of Treaty Benefits. Questions Raised on Taxation of Capital Gains Under India-Mauritius DTAA and Scope of Section 245R(2) Provi

The Supreme Court disposed of the appeals concerning the taxation of capital gains and the scope of Section 245R(2). The Supreme Court disposed of appeals filed by the Authority for Advance Rulings challenging a High Court judgment that had quashed the AAR's rejection of treaty benefits under the India-Mauritius DTAA.

[Lawtext: source](#)

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS3 Revisiting the Farmer Question

India's agriculture sector contributes 15-18 percent of GDP and employs 46 percent of the workforce, remaining central to rural livelihoods despite structural economic shifts. Small and fragmented holdings, water stress, climate risks, rising input costs, and weak value chains continue to limit farm incomes and rural stability. About 86 percent of farmers own less than two hectares, restricting economies of scale, modernization, and overall technology adoption. Intensive irrigation depletes groundwater reserves while nearly half of farmed land depends entirely on unpredictable rainfall patterns.

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Tackling Food Loss and Waste

The International Day of Awareness of Food Loss and Waste renewed calls for India to shift from isolated interventions to a connected national framework. While India rigorously measures farm-to-retail losses through three national surveys, retail, restaurant, and household waste remains entirely unmeasured and lacks accountability. Food loss refers to produce spoiled between farm and shop via poor storage or transport, whereas food waste involves items thrown away by shops, restaurants, and households.

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 In need of an overhaul: on the Election Commission of India's press note

The Election Commission of India issued a press note regarding the Special Intensive Revision, prompting critical editorial review. The editorial critiques the Election Commission of India's press note as a mere damage control exercise and calls for undoing the ill-effects of the Special Intensive Revision. The Election Commission of India's response is mere damage control, the Special Intensive Revision's ill-effects must be undone

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Farmers need a share of the solar boom

India's solar capacity has grown sixtyfold since 2014, but farmers who hold the land own almost none of it as the PM-KUSUM scheme has lagged. PM-KUSUM Component A lacks capital subsidies, forcing farmers to raise full plant costs themselves and preventing the initiative from succeeding. The core issue is that farmers hold the necessary land for solar parks but lack the capital and access to cheap credit to build plants.

[civildaily.com](#)

GS1 The 80s nostalgia holds caste bias

AI-generated retro images of the 1980s have made India the top country for Google's Nano Banana image model, but these images erase marginalized castes. AI image models draw on old film stills, magazine spreads, studio portraits, and family albums that historically belonged to well-off, mostly savarna households. In 1983, 44.5 percent of Indians lived below the poverty line, meaning very few could afford family photographs, while Dalit and Adivasi lives were mainly documented by the state or anthropologists.

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 A smoke and mirrors summit in which Xi emerged with the upper hand

Published as an opinion piece following a major diplomatic summit. An editorial discussing a recent summit and analyzing how Chinese President Xi Jinping outmaneuvered other participants to gain the upper hand.

[Indian Express](#)

GS1 GS2 Uttarakhand's UCC has weakened women's inheritance rights

The implementation and critique of Uttarakhand's Uniform Civil Code brought its impact on women's inheritance rights into public debate. The editorial argues that Uttarakhand's Uniform Civil Code weakens women's inheritance rights by allowing parents to will property away from daughters. Sold as a path to equality, the Uniform Civil Code lets parents will property away from daughters, and leaves Hindu and Muslim women more vulnerable to disinheritance.

[Frontline](#)

GS3 IRDAI insurance commission curbs: Why the industry is facing a reckoning

The IRDAI issued a consultation paper to reform the insurance sector and tighten caps on commissions to protect consumers and ensure transparency. The insurance industry historically bypassed product-level caps by paying overriding commissions (ORC) due to intense competition for a limited pool of distributors. Previous regulatory fixes like Point-of-Sale persons and Motor Insurance Service Providers were turned into new channels for extracting extra commissions.

[Economic Times](#)

GS3 A deeper probe into FCNR(B) swap scheme

The opinion piece discusses the risks associated with the FCNR(B) swap scheme and its broader macroeconomic implications. The editorial warns that temporary relief provided by FCNR(B) swap schemes should not lead to long-term external debt vulnerabilities. Temporary comfort for the near term should not create conditions for a nation to sleepwalk into a debt trap in the longer term

[BusinessLine](#)

GS2 From oil shocks to resilience: What BRICS's new agenda needs to address

The discussion arises from the need for the BRICS grouping to address energy vulnerability and reshape its strategic agenda. An editorial highlighting that fossil fuel projects outnumber renewables across the BRICS bloc, leaving member nations vulnerable to energy crises. Fossil projects outnumber renewables across the bloc, making member nations vulnerable to an energy crisis

[BusinessLine](#)

GS3 BRICS, CBAM and the making of a new carbon trade order

The New Delhi Declaration adopted at the 18th BRICS Summit strongly opposes unilateral, punitive, and protectionist carbon border adjustment mechanisms. The EU CBAM entered its operational phase on January 1, 2026, while the UK's planned CBAM is set for January 1, 2027. India's industrial exports like steel, aluminium, and cement face higher compliance costs and reduced price competitiveness due to reliance on coal-based energy.

[Hindustan Times](#)

GS4 Spontaneous empathy

The piece appeared as an Economic Times opinion article discussing social responsibility, empathy, and human cooperation. Bees demonstrate a strong sense of social responsibility without any formal laws or teachings. In contrast, human societies possess extensive legal frameworks yet struggle with cooperation and empathy. The neglect of basic human needs like love and kindness contributes to this issue. A sense of responsibility can only emerge from developing genuine compassion for others.

[Economic Times](#)

GS2 Between Trump's US and Xi's China, the trap India must avoid

US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping have met twice in 2026, shaping a G2 framework that features a US-China rapprochement and pauses Washington's containment strategy. China has weathered America's offensive phase, forced a strategic stalemate, and emerged as a near-peer, imposing an inevitable peace according to its report. The emerging G2 framework poses structural questions for India and the Global South regarding whether great powers will collude to constrain third powers.

[msn.com](#)

GS3 Trump's tariff war: Fallout of a failed misadventure

It is in the news because a year and a half has passed since the inception of Trump's tariff war. The editorial analyzes the failure and fallout of Donald Trump's tariff war a year and a half after its inception. A year and a half after inception, Trump's tariff war appears to have largely failed

[BusinessLine](#)

GS2 Suo motu selective, PIL choked, constitutional remedies pushed towards ICU

The current state of judicial activism and declining accessibility of public interest litigation. An editorial discussing how selective suo motu actions, choked PILs, and restricted constitutional remedies are weakening access to justice.

[Deccan Herald](#)

GS2 Climate change has a cost. Balen Shah's UNGA speech shows Nepal wants the world to pay

Nepal's Prime Minister Balen Shah delivered a powerful speech at the UNGA on 24 September, highlighting the devastation caused by recent flash floods. Shah warned the global community about the Himalayan tsunami, stating that the Bhote Koshi-Trishuli disaster resulted in 1,400 deaths and 6,000 missing. The core argument demands that major global emitters and industrialised nations pay for the climate costs borne by vulnerable countries like Nepal.

[ThePrint](#)

GS3 Principles of regulation must never be forgotten: Here are five deviations that India must fix right away

It highlights the ongoing need to reform regulatory practices to prevent them from holding back India's economic potential. The editorial argues that Indian regulators, particularly in sectors like insurance, must abandon poor regulatory habits and adhere to sound principles to foster economic growth. However, in insurance and many other sectors, regulators must abandon old habits of ignoring principles for Indian policy to spur economic growth instead of holding it back.

[Mint](#)

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Right to Vote as Fundamental Right – Arguments in Favour & Against A recent investigation found that 97 eligible voters in Goa were excluded from electoral rolls due to centralised ECINet software constraints. This software issue prevented Electoral Registration Officers from reversing voter exclusions, renewing debates on electoral inclusion and voting rights.

[ForumIAS](#)

What is Switzerland's 'neutrality initiative'? Switzerland voted against a proposal aimed at tightening its long-standing policy of neutrality in a nationwide referendum. Around 70 per cent of voters rejected the measure, and majorities in all 26 Swiss regions voted against it. The right-wing Swiss People's Party backed the proposal, arguing Switzerland moved too close to the EU and NATO.

[The Hindu](#)

From Nepal to India, how AI is improving disaster management The increasing deployment of advanced predictive and early warning technologies across South Asian nations to mitigate natural disasters. An explainer on how artificial intelligence tools are transforming disaster management practices from Nepal to India.

[Indian Express](#)

Explained: How the FCRA regulates foreign funding and what the 2026 amendments mean The Ministry of Home Affairs issued comprehensive FAQs clarifying the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act and the proposed 2026 amendments. The FCRA regulates the acceptance, utilisation and reporting of foreign contributions to safeguard national sovereignty and security. During 2024-25, about 16,200 registered associations received approximately Rs 22,963 crore in foreign contributions.

[ddnews.gov.in](#)

What does the Centre's latest decision on NEET-SS seats entail? The decision comes into focus amid concerns over vacant NEET-SS seats and demands raised by doctors from Tamil Nadu. The Centre has made a new decision regarding NEET-SS seats to address vacant super-specialty medical seats and demands from doctors.

[The Hindu](#)

Sea level rise: Can a country retain its statehood even if it loses its territory? The existential threat of climate change and accelerated sea level rise to low-lying island nations has brought the question of statehood continuity to the forefront of international legal debates.

[Indian Express](#)

From Australia's Medicare to US government websites, what recent AI agent incidents have in common It is in the news because of recent high-profile glitches and vulnerabilities exposed by AI agents deployed in government systems. This explainer details recent security incidents and operational failures involving AI agents across public sector platforms like Australia's Medicare and US government websites.

[Indian Express](#)

Can small loans change women's lives? The topic is in the news as a central theme in discussions regarding women-led development and grassroots economic policies. This explainer examines the role of small loans and microfinance in transforming women's lives through economic empowerment and financial inclusion.

[Indian Express](#)

H-1B Visa, US Immigration Rules: Why Rich Indians Are Seeking Second Residency; Is Europe Their 'Plan B'? High-net-worth Indians are increasingly seeking second residencies as mobility insurance, up 25-30% year-on-year in enquiries. Promoters, family offices, tech founders, and senior executives view a second residency as a Plan B rather than immediate emigration. Second residency gives the legal right to reside in another country while retaining Indian citizenship, as dual citizenship is banned.

[news18.com](#)

Talks or strikes? What is Trump's next step in the US-Iran conflict? It is in the news as an analytical explainer on evolving US policy towards Iran. The article explores whether Donald Trump will pursue diplomatic talks or military strikes in the ongoing US-Iran conflict.

[Firstpost](#)

Mint explainer: can a new digital portal change how India insures its livestock? The launch of the digital portal for livestock insurance put the topic in the news. An explainer on how a new digital portal aims to overhaul livestock insurance processes and improve coverage in India.

[Mint](#)

How can India make quality higher education affordable? It highlights the pressing national challenge of matching demographic potential with adequate college-level enrollment capacity. This explainer analyzes the systemic challenges India faces in providing affordable and quality higher education to its burgeoning youth population.

[The Hindu](#)

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- Supreme Court asks Centre to consider exempting Class 6 students from CBSE three-language policy this year (Education) [Bar & Bench](#)
- Insuring the Blue Revolution: How PM-MKSSY Is Transforming Risk Management for Indias Aquaculture Farmers (Agriculture & Allied) [PIB](#)
- India showcases Forest and Landscape Restoration Initiatives at COFO 28, in Rome (Environment & Ecology) [PIB](#)
- INDIAN NAVY TO HOST SECOND EDITION OF COMMANDERS' CONFERENCE 2026 AT NAUSENA BHAWAN, NEW DELHI (Defence) [PIB](#)
- Net mopup under small savings schemes set to exceed Rs 3.6 lakh crore target (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- RBI completes Rs. 1 trillion net debt sale for first time in a decade (Economy) [Business Standard](#)
- SC grants ECI four months to fix TMC symbol dispute (Polity & Constitution) [Hindustan Times](#)
- US exempts India and 19 nations from 100% tariff on certain speciality drugs: Report (International Relations) [Economic Times](#)
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COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 21 must-know, 21 Prelims facts, 47 in the news, 17 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Economy (9), International Relations (8), Environment & Ecology (5), Polity & Constitution (3), Defence (3), Science & Technology (3), Governance & Policy (3), Infrastructure & Energy (2), Internal Security (2), Health (1), History, Art & Culture (1), Social Justice & Welfare (1), Agriculture & Allied (1). **Nothing today in** — Education, Disaster Management, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 7 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 1 · Political change in the neighbourhood: 1 · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 1 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: nothing today

Full text — 44 of 71 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — PIB 9, The Hindu 9, Economic Times 6, Indian Express 5, ddnews.gov.in 4, Mint 4, BusinessLine 4, msn.com 3, Hindustan Times 3, timesofindia.indiatimes.com 3, newsonair.gov.in 2, The Diplomat 1, republicworld.com 1, tribuneindia.com 1

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